

IAM Access Recovery - Permissions Boundaries

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Incident IAM-01: identity policy allows, request is denied

A developer role has an identity-based policy that allows s3:GetObject, yet the request receives AccessDenied. The role also has a permissions boundary that does not allow s3:GetObject.

Evaluation rule

A permissions boundary sets the maximum permissions available to an IAM user or role. It does not grant permission by itself. For identity policies and a boundary, effective permissions are the intersection: the action must be allowed by both. An explicit deny in an applicable policy overrides an allow.

Resolution

Confirm the principal and action in CloudTrail. Review both the identity policy and the boundary, plus any session policy or Organizations SCP. Change only the policy layer that is incorrect according to the approved access design; do not remove the boundary merely to make the request succeed.

Reference

https://docs.aws.amazon.com/IAM/latest/UserGuide/access_policies_boundaries.html

IAM Access Recovery - AssumeRole

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Incident IAM-02: sts:AssumeRole is denied

A source principal cannot assume a target role. Successful role assumption normally requires the caller to be permitted to call sts:AssumeRole and the target role's trust policy to trust that caller. Organization SCPs, permissions boundaries, and session policies can further restrict the request.

Triage

Verify the exact source principal ARN and target role ARN. Inspect the target role trust policy, including Principal and Condition elements such as ExternalId or MFA requirements. Then inspect the caller's applicable policies and explicit denies. Use CloudTrail to confirm which principal made the failed request.

Temporary credentials

After role assumption succeeds, the resulting session can still be restricted by the role policies, a permissions boundary, the passed session policy, and an Organizations SCP. Never place long-lived access keys in a support runbook.